

ART IS FOREVER  
MARIGNY, NOLA



WALK-INS AND  
APPOINTMENTS

Hello,

My name is Sylvia Jones, and I'm writing to you because I have nowhere else to turn. Several weeks ago, my best friend, the one person I trusted most in this whole world, was murdered. Her name was Celestine Broussard. She was an artist, a community leader, and an inspiration who deserved nothing but the best. But somebody shot her dead in St. Louis Cemetery No. 1.

When the police ruled the death a mugging, a friend of mine here in New Orleans referred me to Michelle Gray Investigations. Michelle told me to collect whatever I thought could be helpful and send it all over to you... which is I guess how you do this?

I probably should go back to how it all started. Celestine, me, and our other friend Ines have been tight ever since we first met fifteen years ago. I had just moved here from Jersey, so Cel and Ines became my family in no time. Ines called us the "Bywater Babes" after the neighborhood we all lived in back then, and for a while at least, we did everything together. We even founded our own Carnival krewe, a group for throwing balls and parades during the Mardi Gras season. Celestine named us the "Mystic Krewe of Marie Laveau" (MKML for short), and as captain, she built us a Mardi Gras empire.

But then last February 16<sup>th</sup>, everything changed. It was the night before our big parade, and Ines and I went down to our local bar, Royal Street Social, to meet with Celestine. No surprise, Ines was doing the most... as usual. She's a filmmaker, and she has this documentary on MKML called *The Misfits of Mardi Gras* that she's been working on forever. The whole reason she called the meeting was to demand that Celestine show the trailer at our krewe's ball the following night. Ines was ready for a fight, but when we walked into the Social, Celestine was already there with Jay.

Jay's her small-town first, the boy she left behind to chase her big-city dreams. A few months ago, he showed up in the Bywater like he expected her to just drop everything and pick up where they left off over fifteen years ago. Of course my girl said no chance, but he kept pushing, that is until she shut him down cold that night. After Jay stormed out, Celestine and Ines had an epic showdown about the documentary screening. Then Cel stormed out too.

At the time, I figured she was going to cool off like she always did after an argument with Ines. She had a tradition of leaving an offering at the grave of Marie Laveau the night before the parade, so I thought doing her old ritual might help. I should've gone after her, but I just thought she wanted to be left alone. Looking back on it, I know that's no excuse.

Celestine didn't show up to the MKML parade or ball the next day. With no one to stand in her way, Ines screened her documentary trailer at the ball, and just as it got to the segment on Celestine, I got a call from Cel's mom back in Iberia Parish. One of the cemetery employees found her body early that morning. It had been shoved into one of the raised tombs near Marie's grave. The police declared it a mugging just like that, even though Cel's belongings were found scattered throughout the cemetery. Based on the fact that nothing was stolen, I'm worried it was someone she knew.

I can't help but wonder if she felt something was coming. In the package I sent with this letter, there's a book of old Louisiana legends that Celestine gave me the night she died. She shoved it into my hands right as she was leaving the bar. I thought the note inside was strange, but I know now she wanted me to take action. She must have known something was about to happen, and she was reaching out to me for help.

I owe it to Celestine to make this right. She was more than my best friend. We were family. She was someone who was always there, supporting me and pushing me to stand up for and respect myself. She got me out of bartending and away from a really bad relationship, and she always encouraged me to take my art (and myself) as seriously as she did. I have no idea what I'm supposed to do now that she's gone.

So I really need your help. And here's where I think we should start... her art studio in the Warehouse District. All her stuff was taken out of her house a few weeks ago, and of course the crime scene was cleared up the day after the murder, which means that studio is the only place left where we might find some evidence. Cel used to

bike there every day, and I know for a fact she kept a spare key hidden somewhere along the route from her house to the studio. I just don't know the exact location. Maybe you could figure it out?

To help you find the key's hiding place, I'm sending a box full of documents about Carnival, Celestine, MKML, and whatever else seemed relevant. I'm hoping it's enough for you to come up with a location, because it's all I've got. I've also uploaded Ines's documentary trailer and what I could find on GoodFences to the shared desktop Michelle Gray set up for us at royalstreetcase.com. She said to log in using the password **ORLEANS**.

If you can just get me into her studio, maybe we can find some kind of lead. When you think you've found the place where Cel stashed the key, just use the Contact page on the shared desktop. Send me an email with the subject line STUDIO, and in the body of the message, write the key's exact location.

Thank you so much for working with me. It's good to have someone on my side.

Sylvia Jones



Something else you should know about me is that I draw all day long. I work in a tattoo shop, and it's how I think things through. Something about seeing everything on paper just makes it click. I sent you some notes that I made at the Social about where I think we might search for the key. I'm sorry they're such a mess to read... it's just how my brain works. —SJ